To raise a present sum: therefore, go forth;
Try what my credit can in Venice do:
That shall be rack'd, even to the uttermost,
To furnish thee to Belmont, to fair Portia.
Go, presently inquire, and so will I,
Where money is; and I no question make,
To have it of my trust or for my sake.

[*Exeunt*

183. *present sum:* money that is required now.
184. see how much you can borrow in Venice, giving me as your security.
185. *rack'd:* stretched.
186. *To furnish...Belmont* : to provide what is necessary for you to go to Belmont.
187. *presently:* at once.
188-9. *I...sake:* I have no doubt that I will be able to borrow money either because of my business credit or on account of my personal surety.

Act I : Scene 2

This scene opens in Belmont where Portia, the rich and beautiful heiress resides. She shares with her maid, Nerissa, her doubts concerning her future, due to the strange provisions of her father's will. According to the will, she is to be won by the suitor who chooses correctly from among the three caskets made of gold, silver and lead. Portia ridicules the suitors, who have come earlier to try their luck, showing her disapproval. When Nerissa reminds her of Bassanio, she remembers him and has tender thoughts for him. The scene is in prose and deals in indirect explanations and characterisation.

Scene 2 *Belmont. A room in* Portia's *house. Enter* Portia *and* Nerissa

Portia

By my troth, Nerissa, my little body is aweary of this great world.

Nerissa

You would be, sweet madam, if your miseries were in the same abundance as your good fortunes are: and yet, for aught I see, they are as sick that surfeit with too much as they that starve with nothing. It is no mean happiness therefore, to be seated in the mean: superfluity comes

1. *By my troth:* by my faith.
aweary: tired.
3. *in the same abundance:* as plentiful.
4. *aught:* anything.
5. *surfeit:* are overfed.
6. *with nothing:* with having nothing.
7. *no mean:* not small, poor.
8. *seated...mean:* placed in the middle (between poverty and riches). Nerissa uses the word *mean* in two different meanings: (i) poor (ii) moderate.
6-8. It is no small happiness to be situated in a position mid-way between poverty and riches.

sooner by white hairs, but competency lives
10 longer.

Portia

Good sentences, and well pronounced.

Nerissa

They would be better, if well followed.

Portia

If to do were as easy as to know what were good to do, chapels had been churches, and
15 poor men's cottages princes' palaces. It is a good divine that follows his own instructions: I can easier teach twenty what were good to be done, than be one of the twenty to follow mine own teaching. The brain may devise
20 laws for the blood; but a hot temper leaps o'er a cold decree: such a hare is madness the youth, to skip o'er the meshes of good counsel the cripple. But this reasoning is not in the fashion to choose me a husband. O
25 me, the word "choose"! I may neither choose whom I would, nor refuse whom I dislike; so is the will of a living daughter curbed by the will of a dead father. Is it not hard, Nerissa, that I cannot choose one, nor refuse none?

Nerissa

30 Your father was ever virtuous: and holy men at their death have good inspirations; therefore, the lottery, that he hath devised in these three chests of gold, silver, and lead, — whereof who chooses his meaning

8-9. *superfluity...hairs:* those who have too much of anything *(superfluity)* will age sooner.

9-10. *competency lives longer:* those who have just enough *(competency)* live longer.

11. *sentences:* maxims; proverbs.
pronounced: spoken. Portia, perhaps, is hinting at the legal use of 'sentences' which are legally 'pronounced' by judges.

12. *followed:* obeyed.

13. *to do:* to act.

14. *chapels:* a church which accommodates a small number of worshippers.
had been: would have been.

15. *It:* he.

16. *divine:* preacher.

17. *were:* is.

19. *brain:* reason or mind.
devise: make.

20. *blood:* will or body. Note the distinction between reason and will, or mind and body.

20-1. *a hot temper...decree:* The heat of desire disobeys such cold laws.

21. *cold decree:* good advice.

21-3. *such a ...cripple:* Youthful high spirits are like a hare, which easily leaps *(skip)* over the nets *(meshes)* of limping *(the cripple)* good advice *(counsel).*

23. *reasoning:* wise talk.

24. *in the fashion:* the proper way.
choose me: select for me.

24-5. *O me:* Oh dear.

26. *whom I would:* whom I like.

27. *the will:* two meanings: 'desire' and 'testament'.
curbed: restrained.

29. *nor...none:* the emphatic double negative.

30. *ever:* always.

31. *inspirations:* divine guidance. The idea of the lottery (here really a test of character) was that it would discover the true lover, so that Portia would have no cause to regret being debarred from choosing.

34. *his meaning:* the one that Portia's father meant him to choose.

35 chooses you, — will, no doubt, never be chosen by any rightly but one who shall rightly love. But what warmth is there in your affection towards any of these princely suitors that are
40 already come?

Portia

I pray thee, over-name them; and as thou namest them, I will describe them; and, according to my description, level at my affection.

Nerissa

45 First, there is the Neapolitan prince.

Portia

Ay, that's a colt indeed, for he doth nothing but talk of his horse; and he makes it a great appropriation to his own good parts that he can shoe him himself.

Nerissa

50 Then is there the County Palatine.

Portia

pick anyone you like

He doth nothing but frown; as who should say, "An you will not have me, choose": he hears merry tales, and smiles not: I fear he will prove the weeping philosopher when he
55 grows old, being so full of unmannerly sadness in his youth. I had rather be married to a death's head with a bone in his mouth than to either of these: God defend me from these two!

---

58. *defend:* protect.

36. *rightly:* correctly.

but: except.

41. *over-name them:* call out their names one by one.

43. *level at:* guess.

45. *Neapolitan:* from Naples.

46. *colt:* inexperienced young man (like a young horse).

Neapolitans were famed for their horsemanship.

47-8. *a great...parts:* an addition to his own merits.

48-9. *that...himself:* that he can shoe his own horse.

50. *County Palatine:* The Count from the Palatinate, the region on the west bank of the Rhine; the count is a local ruler or a nobleman.

51-2. *as who should say:* as if he were to say.

54. *prove:* become like.

the weeping philosopher: Heraclitus of Ephesus, who went to live alone in the mountains because he was so distressed by mankind's stupidity.

55-6. *unmannerly sadness:* unpleasant gloom.

56. *I had:* I should.

57. *death's head:* skull; the emblem of a skull, with two bones crossed underneath was usually known as a "death's head."

his: its.

Nerissa

60 How say you by the French lord, Monsieur Le Bon?

Portia

God made him, and therefore let him pass for a man. In truth, I know it is a sin to be a mocker; but, he! — why, he hath a horse better
65 than the Neapolitan's, a better bad habit of frowning than the Count Palatine; he is every man in no man; if a throstle sing, he falls straight a-capering; he will fence with his own shadow: if I should marry him, I should
70 marry twenty husbands. If he would despise me, I would forgive him; for if he love me to madness, I shall never requite him.

Nerissa

What say you, then, to Falconbridge, the young baron of England?

Portia

75 You know I say nothing to him, for he understands not me, nor I him; he hath neither Latin, French, nor Italian; and you will come into the court and swear that I have a poor pennyworth in the English. He
80 is a proper man's picture: but, alas, who can converse with a dumb-show? How oddly he is suited! I think he bought his doublet in Italy, his round hose in France, his bonnet in Germany, and his behaviour everywhere.

Nerissa

85 What think you of the Scottish lord, his neighbour?

---

83. *round hose:* breeches. *bonnet:* hat.

84. *behaviour:* manners.

60. *How say you by:* What do you think of.

60-1. *Monsieur Le Bon:* literally, "Sir, the Good." a satirical expression of the traditional, affected, vivacious Frenchman.

62-3. *pass for:* be accepted as.

63-4. *to be a mocker:* to mock at.

64-5. *he hath a horse better than:* he talks even more than the Neapolitan about his horse.

65. *a better bad habit:* a more exaggerated bad habit.

66-7. *he is...no man*: he has everybody else's characteristics and no personality of his own.

67. *throstle:* thrush, the common English bird.

67-8. *falls.. .a-capering:* immediately starts jumping up and down (to the music).

68. *fence:* draw his sword.

70. *twenty husbands:* because he has every body else's characteristics.

71-2. *love me to madness:* love me passionately.

72. *requite him:* return his love.

73. *say...to:* think of.

76. *hath:* understands.

78. *come into the court:* bear witness.

79. *poor pennyworth:* very little knowledge (as much as could be bought for a penny).

80. *a proper man's picture:* a man of fine appearance.

81. *a dumb-show:* a mime, acting without words.

oddly: strangely.

82. *suited:* dressed.

doublet: jacket.

Portia

That he hath a neighbourly charity in him; for he borrowed a box of the ear of the Englishman, and swore he would pay him again when he was able: I think the Frenchman became his surety, and sealed under for another.

Nerissa

How like you the young German, the Duke of Saxony's nephew?

Portia

Very vilely in the morning, when he is sober, and most vilely in the afternoon, when he is drunk: when he is best, he is a little worse than a man, and when he is worst, he is little better than a beast. An the worst fall that ever fell, I hope I shall make shift to go without him.

Nerissa

If he should offer to choose, and choose the right casket, you should refuse to perform your father's will, if you should refuse to accept him.

Portia

Therefore, for fear of the worst, I pray thee, set a deep glass of Rhenish wine on the contrary casket; for if the devil be within and that temptation without, I know he will choose it. I will do anything, Nerissa, ere I will be married to a sponge.

Nerissa

You need not fear, lady, the having any of these lords: they have acquainted me with their determinations; which is, indeed, to return to their home, and to trouble you with no more suit, unless you may be won by

87. *neighbourly charity:* charity for his neighbour.

88. *borrowed:* was given.

a box of the ear of: a blow on the ear from...

91. *became his surety:* guaranteed that he would repay the debt. Reference is made to the constant assistance that the French gave the Scots in their quarrels with the English.

91-2. *sealed...under:* signed his name underneath the Scotman's signature on the (imaginary) bond as a guarantee for a friend. (Pledged himself that the Scottish lord would repay the Englishman the box on the ear.)

95. *vilely:* badly.

96. *most vilely:* still worse.

97. *best:* at his best.

98. *worst:* at his worst.

99-100. *An...fell:* if the worst thing that could ever happen (*fell*) should happen (*'fall'*).

100. *make shift:* manage.

107. *set a deep glass:* place a large glass. *Rhenish wine:* white wine made from grapes grown in the Rhine valley.

108. *contrary:* wrong.

109. *temptation:* (the wine).

111. *sponge:* one who soaks up or absorbs liquor, drunkard.

112. *the having:* that you will have to accept.

113. *acquainted me with:* informed me of.

114. *determinations:* decisions.

116. *suit:* a request to marry.

some other sort than your father's imposition, depending on the caskets.

Portia

If I live to be as old as Sibylla, I will die as chaste as Diana, unless I be obtained by the manner of my father's will. I am glad this parcel of wooers are so reasonable; for there is not one among them but I dote on his very absence; and I pray God grant them a fair departure.

Nerissa

Do you not remember, lady, in your father's time, a Venetian, a scholar and a soldier, that came hither in company of the Marquis of Montferrat?

Portia

Yes, yes, it was Bassanio: as I think, so was he called.

Nerissa

True, madam: he, of all the men that ever my foolish eyes looked upon, was the best deserving a fair lady.

Portia

I remember him well, and I remember him worthy of thy praise.

Enter a Servant

How now! what news?

Servant

The four strangers seek for you, madam, to take their leave; and there is a forerunner come from a fifth, the Prince of Morocco; who brings word, the prince his master will be here tonight.

117. *sort:* means.

your father's imposition: the conditions imposed by your father.

depending on: based on the choice of.

119. *Sibylla:* the Sibyl is a prophetess in Roman mythology. Apollo granted her as many years of life as there were sand grains she held in her hand. Here, she is used as the traditional old woman.

120. *Diana:* the goddess of virginity in Roman mythology. She was also the goddess of hunting and of the moon.

122. *parcel of wooers:* crowd of suitors.

123. *dote on:* long for.

123-4. *but I...absence:* whom I do not wish to be absent.

127. *a scholar and a soldier:* Ironic, since Bassanio is neither of them. Nerissa says what Portia wants to hear.

128-9. *Marquis of Montferrat:* the title of an Italian nobleman, (who would have been known by name in England at this time).

130-1. *as I think...called:* Portia pretends to have forgotten his name so as not to appear too keen on him.

137. *How now, what news?:* Hello, what news?

138. *four strangers:* six have been mentioned earlier. Possible explanations for this are : (a) Shakespeare seems to have forgotten that six suitors have been discussed (b) the Scottish and English lords were added to the scene to amuse the audience. (c) the servant regards two of the suitors with such contempt that they are not even worth mentioning.

139. *forerunner:* messenger.

Portia

If I could bid the fifth welcome with so good heart as I can bid the other four farewell, I should be glad of his approach: if he have the condition of a saint and the complexion of a devil, I had rather he should shrive me than wive me.

Come, Nerissa. — *Sirrah,* go before.—

Whiles we shut the gate upon one wooer, another knocks at the door. *[Exeunt*

145. *approach:* arrival.
146. *condition:* nature.
complexion: appearance.
147. *I had:* I should prefer.
shrive me: hear my sins and grant forgiveness like a holy man.
148. *wive:* marry.
149. *Sirrah:* expression addressing a servant.

Act I: Scene 3

In this scene, Shylock, the Jewish moneylender, is introduced. He is the most powerful dramatic figure in the play. Shylock's hatred for Antonio intensifies the drama. Having been ridiculed by Antonio for years, he does not want to lend money to his friend Bassanio. But foreseeing an opportunity to take his revenge on Antonio, he agrees to give the loan on a bond which would allow Shylock to cut off a pound of Antonio's flesh, if he fails to repay the loan in time. The bond story is the main plot around which all action in the play takes place.

Scene 3 *Venice. A public place*
Enter Bassanio *and* Shylock

Shylock

Three thousand ducats, — well.

1. *ducats:* Venetian gold coins.

Bassanio

Ay, sir, for three months.

2. *Ay:* yes.

Shylock

For three months, — well.

Bassanio

For the which, as I told you, Antonio shall be bound.

4. *For the which:* for which.
4-5. *be bound:* act as surety, as guarantor

Shylock

Antonio shall become bound, — well.

6. *well:* understand.